

Typography Cheat Sheet for UI Designers

A practical UI typography cheat sheet covering typography hierarchy, font sizes, font weights, line height, letter spacing, font pairing, responsive typography, and accessibility for web and mobile interfaces.

Who it's for
UI/UX students, beginner and junior UI designers, Figma users, web designers, and mobile app designers.

How to use it
Start with the suggested values, apply them to real screens, then adjust for your font, product, and users.

Important
Every number here is a practical starting point, not a universal rule. Always test with real content.

PRACTICAL STARTING POINTS · ADAPT TO YOUR PRODUCT

Quick UI Typography Reference

Element	Recommended starting size	Weight	Typical use
H1	40–48px desktop · 28–32px mobile	700 Bold	One page title or hero headline per page
H2	32–36px desktop · 24–26px mobile	600–700	Major page sections
H3	24–28px desktop · 20–22px mobile	600 Semibold	Subsections, card group titles
H4	20px desktop · 18px mobile	600 Semibold	Card titles, supporting headings
Body	16px (15–18px range)	400 Regular	Paragraphs and main reading text
Small	14px	400 Regular	Secondary info, table cells, descriptions
Caption	12px	400–500	Metadata, timestamps, helper text
Button	14–16px	500–600	Actions and calls to action

01 Typography Fundamentals

The basic terms you will use every time you set type in Figma or code.

Typeface vs font
A typeface is the design (e.g. Inter). A font is one specific style of it (e.g. Inter Semibold 16px). In everyday UI work the words are often used interchangeably.

Serif vs sans-serif
Serif typefaces have small strokes at letter ends (Merriweather). Sans-serif typefaces don't (Inter, Roboto). Most UI text uses sans-serif for clarity on screens.

Font family
The full set of styles in a typeface: weights, italics, and sometimes widths. Using one family with a few weights keeps an interface consistent.

Font weight
How thick the strokes are, from Thin (100) to Black (900). Weight creates emphasis and helps build hierarchy.

Font size

How large the text is, usually set in px in design tools and rem/px in code. Size is the strongest signal of importance.

Line height

The vertical space a line of text takes up (leading). Written as a multiplier (1.5) or px (24px). It strongly affects readability.

Letter spacing

The space between characters (tracking). Small adjustments help large headings and all-caps labels; body text usually needs none.

Text hierarchy

The visual order of importance created with size, weight, color, and spacing, so users know what to read first.

02 UI Typography Hierarchy

A simple typography hierarchy that works for most websites, dashboards, and apps.

Level	Role	Recommended use cases
H1	Page title	Hero headline, page name, article title. Use once per page.
H2	Major section	Landing page sections, settings groups, article sections.
H3	Subsection	Groups inside a section, feature titles, form section titles.
H4	Supporting heading	Card titles, modal titles, list group headers, sidebar headings.
Body	Main content	Paragraphs, descriptions, form inputs, most readable text.
Small text	Supporting information	Secondary descriptions, table data, list item details, footnotes.
Caption	Metadata / helper text	Timestamps, image captions, form hints, character counters, tags.

Tip: heading levels in code (h1–h4) should follow the content structure, not just visual size. Style and semantics can be set separately.

03 Recommended Font Sizes

A font size guide for UI design on desktop and mobile. Values assume a typical sans-serif such as Inter or Roboto.

Desktop			Mobile		
Level	Size	Line height	Level	Size	Line height
H1	40–48px	1.1–1.2	H1	28–32px	1.15–1.2
H2	32–36px	1.2	H2	24–26px	1.2–1.25
H3	24–28px	1.25–1.3	H3	20–22px	1.3
H4	20px	1.3	H4	18px	1.3–1.35
Body	16–18px	1.5–1.6	Body	16px	1.5
Small text	14px	1.45	Small text	14px	1.45
Caption	12px	1.4	Caption	12px	1.4

These are starting points, not rules. Fonts with a small x-height (e.g. Garamond) may need larger sizes; wide fonts (e.g. Poppins) may need smaller ones. Content-heavy products like blogs often use 18px body text, while dense dashboards may use 14px for tables. Adjust based on your product, font, and context, then test on real devices.

04 Font Weights

Most interfaces only need three or four font weights.

Weight	Best UI use cases	Watch out for
Regular / 400	Body text, paragraphs, input values, table data, descriptions.	Can look too light for headings below 20px.
Medium / 500	Navigation links, labels, buttons, tabs, emphasized small text.	Too close to Regular in some fonts; check the difference is visible.
Semibold / 600	H3–H4 headings, card titles, buttons, table headers, active states.	Using it everywhere removes contrast in the hierarchy.
Bold / 700	H1–H2 headings, hero headlines, key numbers in dashboards.	Long bold paragraphs are tiring to read.

05 Line Height Guide

Line height in UI design controls how easy text is to scan and read. Too tight and lines collide; too loose and the eye loses its place moving to the next line.

Text type	Starting line height	Why
Large headings (32px+)	1.1–1.2	Big text already has visual space; tight leading keeps multi-line headlines together.
Regular headings	1.2–1.35	Keeps headings compact but readable when they wrap.
Body text	1.5–1.6	Gives the eye room to track long lines of text comfortably.
Small text	1.4–1.5	Small sizes need proportionally more space to stay legible.
Buttons	1–1.25 (single line)	Height comes from padding; tight leading keeps labels centered.
Forms	Labels 1.3–1.4 · inputs 1.4–1.5	Clear labels and comfortable input text, with room for helper and error text.

Tip: round line heights to your spacing grid (e.g. multiples of 4px). 16px body × 1.5 = 24px.

06 Letter Spacing

Small, deliberate changes only. Excessive letter spacing breaks up word shapes and reduces readability.

Text type	Starting letter spacing	Notes
Large headings	-0.01em to -0.02em	Slightly tighter spacing makes big text look more solid.
Body text	0 (default)	Fonts are designed to read well at their default spacing.
All-caps labels	+0.04em to +0.08em	Capitals sit close together; extra space improves legibility.
Buttons	0 to +0.01em (all-caps: ~+0.04em)	Keep sentence-case buttons at default spacing.
Small UI text	0 to +0.01em	A tiny increase can help 11–12px text; never tighten it.

07 Font Pairing

Font pairing for UI design is about contrast with harmony. Most interfaces need one or two font families.

Heading + body pairing
Give headings personality and keep body text highly readable.

Serif + sans-serif
A classic contrast. A serif heading adds character; a sans-serif body stays clean.

Sans-serif + sans-serif
Works when the two differ clearly (geometric vs neutral). Otherwise use one family.

Limit font families
Two families is usually enough. A single family with multiple weights is often best for product UI.

Maintain visual hierarchy
The pairing should make headings and body text easy to tell apart at a glance.

Check readability
Test both fonts at small sizes, on mobile, and in real layouts before committing.

Example pairing	Style	Good for
Inter + Merriweather	Sans-serif UI with a readable serif for long-form text	Blogs, documentation, content platforms
Playfair Display + Inter	Elegant serif headings with a neutral sans-serif body	Portfolios, lifestyle, premium brands
Roboto + Merriweather	Familiar sans-serif with a sturdy serif	News, editorial, education sites
Poppins + Open Sans	Friendly geometric headings with a readable humanist body	Startups, SaaS landing pages, apps

All four pairings use free fonts available on Google Fonts and in Figma.

08 UI Typography Examples

The typography decisions that matter most in common interface patterns.

Example	Important typography decisions
Website hero	One strong H1 (40–56px desktop), a short supporting paragraph at 18–20px, tight heading line height, and a clear button label. Keep headlines to roughly 2–3 lines.
Navigation	14–16px Medium labels, consistent casing, clear active state that doesn't rely on weight alone (add color or an underline).
Cards	Title in H4 Semibold, 14–16px description, 12px metadata. Limit description length so cards stay aligned.
Forms	Visible labels (14px Medium) above inputs, 16px input text (prevents auto-zoom on iOS), 12–14px helper and error text with an icon, not color alone.
Buttons	14–16px Medium or Semibold, sentence case, short action verbs ("Save changes"), same style for the same importance level.
Dashboard	Large bold numbers for key metrics, 12–14px labels, tabular (monospaced) figures for aligned numbers, restrained heading sizes to keep density.
Mobile app	16px body, 17–20px screen titles, 44px+ tap targets around text links, and fewer levels of hierarchy than desktop.

09 Responsive Typography

Web and mobile typography need different sizes but the same hierarchy.

Desktop vs mobile sizing

Headings shrink the most on mobile (often 30–40% smaller). Body text usually stays at 16px.

Maintain hierarchy

Each level must still look clearly different from the next after scaling down.

Avoid oversized mobile headings

A 48px headline on a 375px screen fits only a few words per line and pushes content below the fold.

Use a responsive type scale

Use a ratio such as 1.2 on mobile and 1.25–1.333 on desktop, or CSS `c1amp()` for fluid sizes.

Check small-screen readability

Aim for roughly 45–75 characters per line on desktop and test on a real phone, not just a resized browser.

Define styles per breakpoint

Document desktop and mobile values for each text style in your Figma file or design system.

10 Typography Accessibility

Accessible typography helps everyone read faster, not only users with visual impairments.

- **Readable font sizes:** use 16px for body text and avoid going below 12px for any UI text.
- **Sufficient contrast:** WCAG AA asks for at least 4.5:1 for normal text and 3:1 for large text (24px regular or ~19px bold).
- **Comfortable line height:** at least 1.5 for body text and paragraphs.
- **Avoid overly condensed fonts:** narrow letterforms are harder to read, especially at small sizes.
- **Avoid excessive all-caps text:** keep it for short labels; long uppercase text is slower to read.
- **Don't rely only on font weight to communicate meaning:** pair it with color, icons, underlines, or text.
- **Test text at different screen sizes:** and with browser zoom at 200% to make sure nothing breaks or overlaps.

11 Typography Mistakes to Avoid

- | | |
|---|---|
| ✗ Too many fonts in one interface | ✗ Inconsistent heading sizes across pages |
| ✗ Too many font weights | ✗ Inconsistent line heights |
| ✗ Very small body text | ✗ Long paragraphs without hierarchy |
| ✗ Poor contrast between text and background | ✗ Using decorative fonts for body text |
| ✗ Excessive letter spacing | |

★ Typography Tips for Beginners

Start with one font

Inter or Roboto with 3–4 weights can handle an entire interface.

Set body text first

Choose a comfortable 16px body style, then build headings up from it.

Use a type scale

Pick a ratio and stick to it instead of choosing random sizes.

Create text styles in Figma

Save every level as a text style so the whole team stays consistent.

Use size and weight together

Hierarchy is clearer when you combine two signals, not five.

Design with real content

Lorem ipsum hides long names, wrapping headings, and translation issues.

12 Quick Typography Checklist

Run through this before handing off a design.

☐ Font family selected

☐ Heading hierarchy defined

☐ Body size readable

☐ Font weights consistent

☐ Line heights checked

☐ Letter spacing checked

☐ Font pairing reviewed

☐ Mobile typography checked

☐ Contrast checked

☐ Accessibility considered

☐ Typography works across the interface

☐ Design system typography styles are documented